EXCEL DASHBOARD PRACTICAL HANDBOOK

Pizza Barn Customer Service | Lessons 126-137

A step-by-step guide to business questions, PivotTables, PivotCharts, slicers, timelines, themes, and final dashboard polish. Includes practice examples and revision checklists.

Learning phase	Lessons	Outcome
Plan the dashboard	126-128	Identify questions and prepare workbook
Build business answers	129-130	Create PivotTables and select charts
Clean and explain	131-134	Align, simplify, add titles, introduce storytelling
Make it interactive	135	Connect slicers and a date timeline
Polish and validate	136-137	Apply visual theme, refine pie labels and retest

Source note: Lessons 135-137 follow the supplied instructor transcript. Lesson 134 is an introductory storytelling overview only because the detailed teaching was not included. Practice figures are illustrative, not official instructor dataset results.

126 | Introduction to Excel Dashboards

A dashboard gathers important business metrics and visualizations into one view so management can monitor performance and make decisions. The Pizza Barn example includes operational questions from customer service, finance, products, and marketing.

The eight-step dashboard workflow

Step	Purpose
1. Environment setup	Prepare the dashboard and PivotTable worksheets
2. Business answers	Use PivotTables to answer management questions
3. Create charts	Choose visualizations suited to the question
4. Align charts	Use consistent sizing and layout
5. Remove distractions	Hide redundant gridlines, buttons, legends, and borders
6. Bring out insights	Use clear titles, legible labels and number formats
7. Add slicers	Allow interactive selection across charts
8. Apply colors and themes	Create a consistent visual presentation

Remember: Understand the dataset and the questions before building charts.

127 | Generate Business Questions from Data

Start with an important metric; add categorical helper fields; choose a calculation. For example: Sales Amount + Order Type + Agent + SUM answers "What are total sales by agent and order type?"

Component	Example	Question produced
Metric	Sales Amount	What numerical outcome matters?
Helper field 1	Order Type: Online / Physical Visit	How do channels compare?
Helper field 2	Agent: Ross / Adrian / Albion	How do agents compare within each channel?
Aggregation	SUM, AVERAGE, COUNT	Total sales, average order value, or order count

Two order types multiplied by three agents produces six groups. SUM and AVERAGE give different views of those same groups. Count unique order IDs for orders; SUM products ordered for total items; do not confuse the two.

```
=SUMIFS(E2:E13,B2:B13,"Online",C2:C13,"Ross")

=AVERAGEIFS(E2:E13,B2:B13,"Online",C2:C13,"Ross")
```

Practice

Generate questions for total sales by channel, average sales per agent and channel, number of orders per channel, and average discount by agent. Choose questions that lead to decisions rather than producing every possible combination.

128 | Prepare the Dashboard Environment

• Hide unrelated source worksheets instead of deleting them.

• Create CS-Pivot for analysis and CS-Dashboard for presentation.

• In CS-Dashboard, use View > Gridlines to hide worksheet gridlines and View > Headings to hide column letters and row numbers.

• Try a dashboard zoom of 60%-75%, adjusting for readability.

• Optionally collapse the ribbon with Ctrl + F1 or hide the formula bar.

• Choose a layout before starting chart placement.

Suggested layout: four compact categorical comparisons at the top; two wider daily trend charts underneath. Keep slicer and timeline near the dashboard header.

129 | Create Business Answers with PivotTables

Select the Customer Service dataset, choose Insert > PivotTable, and position the result on CS-Pivot. Copy existing PivotTables when useful, leaving sufficient space for expansion and chart experiments.

Business question	Rows	Values / summary
Average CSAT by Agent	Agent_Handle	Average of Rating_Given
Interactions by Agent	Agent_Handle	Count of Interaction_ID
Interactions by Contact Type	Contact_Type	Count of Interaction_ID
Average CSAT by Contact Type	Contact_Type	Average of Rating_Given
Daily Satisfaction	Contact_Date	Average of Rating_Given
Daily Interactions	Contact_Date	Count of Interaction_ID

For averages: right-click a value or use Value Field Settings > Summarize Values By > Average. Format with Number Format (often one decimal). Excel may automatically group dates by months or years; right-click and Ungroup when individual dates are required.

Data caution: Count nonblank interaction identifiers when ratings might be missing. The instructor counts ratings in examples where those fields are populated.

130 | Select and Create Dashboard Charts

PivotTable answer	Suggested chart	Reason
Average CSAT by Agent	Clustered Column	Compare agents
Interactions by Agent	Clustered Column	Compare workload
Interactions by Contact Type	Pie	Show proportion of total
Average CSAT by Contact Type	Clustered Bar	Compare category averages
Daily Satisfaction	Line	See time trends
Daily Interactions	Area	Emphasize quantity over time

Select a PivotTable, then PivotTable Analyze > PivotChart. Experiment with alternatives, but choose the simplest chart that makes the answer clear. Line charts with many markers may become cluttered. Pie charts should represent meaningful parts of a whole, not unrelated averages.

131 | Arrange and Align Charts

• Select each chart border and press Ctrl + X; paste on CS-Dashboard with Ctrl + V. Alternatively, use Chart Design > Move Chart > Object in CS-Dashboard.

• Use Chart Format > Size to apply consistent dimensions to similar charts; the instructor demonstrates about 3.6 high x 6.5 wide in Excel display units.

• Give date trends more horizontal space; the instructor experiments with wider settings around 10.5.

• Temporarily enable worksheet gridlines, turn on Format > Align > Snap to Grid when supported, and line up chart edges.

• Hide worksheet gridlines again after positioning.

Excel measurements can appear in different units depending on regional settings. Use exact relative consistency rather than copying a number that does not fit your own display.

132 | Remove Chart Distractions

Distraction	Excel operation	Important exception
Chart gridlines	Chart Design > Add Chart Element > Gridlines > None	Keep subtle gridlines when needed for estimates
Pivot field buttons	PivotChart Analyze > Field Buttons > Hide All	Hiding does not disconnect the pivot
Single-series legend	Chart Design > Add Chart Element > Legend > None	Retain categorical pie legend until direct labels exist
Chart outline	Chart Format > Shape Outline > No Outline	Keep purposeful separators if useful

Keep meaningful chart titles, categories, scales, and labels. Cleaning a dashboard means removing redundancy, not removing all information.

133 | Add Insights and Dynamic Titles

A clear title tells the viewer which metric and categories they are seeing. Rather than retyping the title into each chart, the instructor links chart titles to cells in CS-Pivot.

Link a chart title to a cell

• Enter the title text into a worksheet cell, such as CS-Pivot!A1.

• Click the chart title once, then click the formula bar.

• Type =, select the source cell, and press Enter.

• Change the source cell text later to update the title automatically.

```
='CS-Pivot'!$A$1
```

Increase text sizes to remain legible at the dashboard zoom; the instructor tries approximately 12 pt here. Add data labels to categorical comparison charts when exact values matter. Avoid labels on every day of a dense timeline. Remove redundant numerical axes only if the chart remains interpretable. Format CSAT averages to a sensible decimal precision.

134 | Dashboard Storytelling: Introductory Overview

Coverage note: The detailed instructor walkthrough for storytelling was not provided. This section captures only the short introductory explanation used in the learning sequence.

Question	Pizza Barn example
What happened?	Agent average satisfaction differs
Where?	Compare agents or contact types
Why does it matter?	A lower score flags an area for investigation
What next?	Review interactions, staffing, or customer-service process

A chart shows evidence; a dashboard story explains the takeaway without claiming causation that the data does not establish.

135 | Slicers and Timelines

A slicer filters PivotTables by category

Select a PivotTable > PivotTable Analyze > Insert Slicer. The instructor uses a field equivalent to Did the customer call for an order?, with Yes/No choices. Clicking Yes or No shows different average customer satisfaction by agent.

Connect a slicer to all PivotTables

• Select slicer > Slicer tab > Report Connections (or PivotTable Connections).

• Check all compatible PivotTables; the instructor connects six of them.

• Compatible PivotTables usually share the same PivotTable cache or data-model source.

• Cut the slicer from CS-Pivot and paste onto CS-Dashboard. Resize it near the upper-right of the dashboard.

• Set the slicer Columns value to 2 to display Yes and No side by side.

Create a timeline

• Select a PivotTable > PivotTable Analyze > Insert Timeline.

• Choose Contact_Date; timelines require recognized date fields.

• Cut and paste the timeline onto CS-Dashboard, near the slicer.

• Select Months, Quarters, Years or Days; the instructor chooses Months.

• Open the timeline Report Connections and check the compatible PivotTables.

• Use Clear Filter to return to the unfiltered state.

Key insight: A slicer and a timeline work together: "Called for an Order = Yes" and "March" shows only records matching both filters. When only one chart responds, revisit Report Connections.

136 | Dashboard Colors and Themes

Instructor workflow

• Select a dashboard worksheet range slightly larger than the visible report; choose Home > Fill Color. The instructor experiments with light blue and later chooses a lighter greyish tone.

• Select each chart > Chart Format > Shape Fill > No Fill. If the plot area remains white, remove that fill separately.

• Realign the slicer and timeline after applying color; misalignments often become easier to see.

• Increase chart text to around 16 pt in the demonstration, adjusting to avoid overlap.

• Use Insert > Shapes > Line to separate dashboard sections. Choose a subtle Shape Outline color and thin weight.

• For one chart, use Chart Design > Change Colors. For overall design, explore Page Layout > Themes or Page Layout > Colors.

Difference: Themes include coordinated colors, fonts, and effects; Colors modifies a theme-aware color palette. Fixed custom-formatting may not respond to theme changes. Follow your organization's brand palette where appropriate.

137 | Final Dashboard Customizations

1. Adjust the plot area

Select the plot area within each crowded chart, and adjust its upper edge or dimensions to add breathing room between the title and bars. This changes layout, not values.

2. Emphasize the titles

Click each chart title and press Ctrl + B to make titles bold and consistent.

3. Add subtle shadows

Right-click Chart Area > Format Chart Area > Effects > Shadow. The instructor experiments with about 40% transparency and blur of roughly 7-12 pt. Keep effects subtle. Format Painter may copy compatible formatting, but shadow effects sometimes need manual repetition.

4. Convert the pie chart to direct labels

• Right-click a pie label > Format Data Labels.

• Enable Category Name and Percentage; disable Value.

• Remove the redundant separate legend.

• Right-click pie > Format Data Series > Angle of First Slice to rotate and improve the label arrangement.

• Pie Explosion moves slices apart, but the instructor rejects heavy explosion here.

• Click labels individually and reposition them if needed.

5. Retest every connection

Test the Yes/No slicer, select different months in the timeline, verify all six PivotCharts update, then clear filters. Review chart labels, shadows, visual contrast, spacing, and number formatting.

Final Dashboard Quality Checklist

[ ] Questions are tied to actionable business decisions.

[ ] All six PivotTables have the correct grouping and aggregation.

[ ] The six PivotCharts use understandable chart types.

[ ] Charts are consistently sized and aligned.

[ ] Worksheet/chart gridlines and redundant field buttons/legends are addressed.

[ ] Titles are clear; chart title cell links work.

[ ] Comparison chart labels show suitable precision.

[ ] Slicer connects to every intended compatible PivotTable.

[ ] Timeline filters the expected date ranges and is connected.

[ ] Backgrounds, typography, separators and colors are consistent.

[ ] Pie category labels and percentages are readable.

[ ] Filtered and cleared states have been tested.

Short interview / review questions

Question	Answer
Why build PivotTables first?	They establish reliable aggregated answers before charting.
Why might one slicer not filter every chart?	Report Connections or data-source/cache compatibility.
How is a Timeline different from a slicer?	A Timeline filters a recognized date field by period.
When should a legend remain?	When needed to identify distinct categories or series.
Why link titles to cells?	Edit labels centrally and update connected charts.
What is the best visualization?	One that communicates the intended business comparison or trend clearly.

End of the Pizza Barn dashboard module (Lessons 126-137).